Yes, Pakistan has its own problems. Sure, there are a lot of crazy people in our country. But our elected leaders don't go around saying that they will break up India into a thousand pieces. That's the difference between their leaders and ours. This new style of politics that has gripped India is disturbing, with their leaders, ministers, even Prime Minister Modi, going on about teaching Pakistan a 'lesson'. It's also disturbing to see videos of their officials propagating violence and the breakup of a sovereign state, while not condemning barbaric acts from within, like beef lynchings, love jihad, or even dealing with populist outrage over a Bollywood flick, as happened with *Bajirao Mastani* and *Padmaavat*.

For the record, as a Pakistani, I'm an isolationist – we need to first and foremost get our own house in order. But because I'm a cricketer, and you cannot avoid talking about India as a Pakistani cricketer, the vitriol and hate from India against my country has never been louder and I must critique it. Of course, there have been ups and downs – mostly downs, unfortunately – in the relationship between the two countries. But I remember, in comparison to recent times, during the days of Atal Bihari Vajpayee sahib's prime ministership, when the same BJP was in power, things were very, very different. Vajpayee sahib's India, under his leadership, was a class apart.

Clearly, today things have a taken a turn for the worse. India's politics of democracy has morphed into the politics of populism. See, there is a difference between democracy and majoritarianism – the equitable rule of the people versus the rule of the mob. The current Indian government doesn't seem to know that difference.

If I were foreign minister for a day, I would get on a plane and go to India and tell them just one thing: calm down your internal narrative. Tell your media to chill out. It exaggerates, it lies and it creates hateful content which ruins the great game of cricket, a game both our countries absolutely love. After all, cricket is the only common love we have left, it seems. It's also the best chance for actual people-to-people contact. Cricket diplomacy has worked in the past. Why ruin that one, lonely yet potent platform?

In my language, Pashto, we say: 'Don't insult my bad mother, and I won't kill your good mother.' It means that regardless of who is at fault, regardless of who sends spies and who sends militants and regardless of who tried to break up or separate a state or a wing or a province, we need to leave a backdoor open for peace.

That backdoor is cricket.

Still, reality bites. I recall that the bad press in India about Pakistan really started during the 2011 World Cup. Their sensationalism went over the top in that tournament and really bad reporting from the Indian media became the standard norm. And then, on the 2016 tour, when I made that now-famous statement about how Indian crowds give Pakistani players more love than Pakistani crowds, the way the Indian media reported my comment, all hell broke loose. Oh, boy! Not only did that statement blow up back home – it was expected to not go down well in some sectors of Pakistan – but what hurt me was that it was taken totally out of context by the Indian media who reported that I hated Pakistan and loved India more. Unbelievable!

Here I was, trying to act like a responsible ambassador of peace – something every cricketer should do when he's on tour. Instead, the Indian media tainted my statement with harsh, xenophobic jingoism, ran it out of context and got me into serious trouble at home and abroad. All I meant to do was thank the local crowds in India for their support. It's shocking what this